

The Pipeline — Website Build Spec

How to use this: Paste this entire document into Claude Code as the build brief. Execute the **Phases** in Section 9, in order. **Design quality is the #1 priority** — every choice must serve the "Blueprint & Signal / conduit" concept in Section 3. A Figma MCP connector is available; use it to build the design system and screen designs *first* (Phase 1), then implement in code with high fidelity. Treat the tokens, components, and copy in this spec as the source of truth.

1. Project brief

What it is. The Pipeline is a fellow-run community at UC Irvine that moves underrepresented technologists into top tech roles by handing them the things that are normally gatekept: hidden/early job & internship postings, resume reviews, mock interviews, and a community that pulls each other up.

What to build. A fast, production-grade, fully responsive **multi-page marketing website** (5 pages + a 404) with a distinctive, memorable visual identity — not a template.

Audience. Ambitious undergrad CS students, many of them first-generation or otherwise underrepresented. They are tech-savvy and allergic to "charity" / corny nonprofit energy. The site must feel like an *insider channel they want to be let into*.

The site's single job. Get the right students to **join** (Discord + interest form), made credible by the **placements** they see. Every page funnels toward Join.

Voice. Confident, plain, a little edgy. It reclaims the "pipeline problem" narrative — "We *don't fix the pipeline. We are the pipeline.*" Never pity, never buzzwords, never "empowering synergies." Specific beats clever.

2. Tech stack

Use **Astro + Tailwind CSS + TypeScript**. Astro is the best fit: content/marketing site, ships ~0 KB JS by default (great Lighthouse scores), first-class components (solves shared header/footer), trivial deploy. Add tiny client islands only where motion needs them.

```
bash
```

```
npm create astro@latest the-pipeline -- --template minimal --typescript strict
cd the-pipeline
npx astro add tailwind react sitemap --yes # react only for the few interactivi
npm install
```

Project structure (target):

```
src/
  components/
    Layout.astro          # <head>, fonts, SEO slots, skip-link, global
wrappers
  Header.astro            # sticky nav, active-link aware
  Footer.astro
  ui/
    Button.astro          # primary | ghost | ghostDark
    Eyebrow.astro
    SectionHead.astro
    Conduit.astro         # the signature animated rail
    DropFeed.tsx          # the placements marquee (island)
    StatGrid.astro / Stat.astro
    StageCard.astro
    FeatureCard.astro
    OutcomeCard.astro     # + CTA variant
    StepRow.astro
    Checklist.astro
    Callout.astro
    CtaBand.astro
    JoinCard.astro
    Faq.astro / FaqItem.astro
    ScrollReveal.tsx     # IntersectionObserver wrapper (island)
pages/
  index.astro
  how.astro
  outcomes.astro
  about.astro
  join.astro
  404.astro
data/
  site.ts                 # nav, placements[], stats[], faq[], links
(Discord/form/contact)
  styles/
    global.css            # @tailwind + tokens + base + reduced-motion
public/
  favicon.svg
  og.png                  # social card (generate; see §7)
  robots.txt
astro.config.mjs          # set `site:` for sitemap + canonicals
tailwind.config.ts
```

Put all real content (placements, stats, FAQ, links) in `src/data/site.ts` so it's edited in one place. A working HTML/CSS prototype of this exact design already exists (the `the-pipeline` folder) — you may drop it in as a visual reference, but this spec is self-contained.

3. Design system — "Blueprint & Signal"

3.1 Concept

The brand *is* a conduit: talent enters, gatekept access flows through, offers come out. Gatekeeping is dark, locked, hidden — so this site is the opposite: **light, lit, blueprint-clean**, with a single electric-blue "current" running through it and a warm coral reserved *only* for the human payoff (a landing, an arrival). The page reads like an engineering blueprint that's alive with flow.

The signature element (spend your boldness here, keep everything else quiet): a thin **conduit rail** with an animated current, feeding a horizontal "**drop feed**" — a marquee of company/program names moving through a pipe like cargo, each tagged with a coral "landed" dot. Talent enters at the hero; offers stream out in the feed below it.

3.2 Anti-patterns (do NOT do these)

AI-generated design clusters around three looks — avoid all three: (1) cream/serif/terracotta editorial; (2) near-black bg with one acid-green/vermillion accent; (3) broadsheet hairline-rule newspaper grid. Also: no stock "diverse people pointing at laptops" photos, no generic gradient-blob hero, no emoji-as-decoration. Logo-soup of real company marks is out (trademark + visual noise) — render placements as **typeset names**, which looks more intentional anyway.

3.3 Color tokens

Light surfaces by default; ink-dark bands for the feed, mission, CTA, and footer.

Token	Hex	Use
<code>bg</code>	<code>#EEF1F8</code>	page background (cool blueprint paper)
<code>surface</code>	<code>#FFFFFF</code>	cards, lifted panels
<code>ink</code>	<code>#0A1730</code>	primary text + dark bands
<code>ink-2</code>	<code>#0E2147</code>	lifted dark surface
<code>ink-soft</code>	<code>#46506A</code>	muted body text
<code>line</code>	<code>#D2DAEC</code>	hairlines/borders on light
<code>brand</code>	<code>#2C57F6</code>	the current — primary accent, links, primary buttons
<code>brand-deep</code>	<code>#1B3CC2</code>	hover/active
<code>brand-soft</code>	<code>#DEE6FE</code>	tinted fills, callout bg
<code>signal</code>	<code>#FF5A36</code>	coral — arrivals only (landed dots, hero underline, CTA topline)
<code>on-dark</code>	<code>#EEF1F8</code>	text on ink
<code>on-dark-soft</code>	<code>#B7C2DD</code>	muted text on ink
<code>on-dark-blue</code>	<code>#8FA6FF</code>	eyebrows/links on ink
<code>dark-line</code>	<code>rgba(255,255,255,0.14)</code>	hairlines on ink

Discipline rule: `brand` blue = the system / flow / "get in." `signal` coral = a human win / arrival. Never use coral decoratively. This tension *is* the brand.

3.4 Typography

Three roles, all on Google Fonts (self-host via `@fontsource`) for performance — see §7):

- **Display** — `Bricolage Grotesque` (600/700/800): characterful, modern, used for all headlines.
- **Body** — `Inter` (400/500/600): clean, legible, everything else.

- **Mono** — `JetBrains Mono` (400/500/700): eyebrows, labels, stats, the drop-feed, footer meta. *Deliberate choice* — it's the font these CS students stare at in their editor all day.

Type scale (use `clamp` for fluid sizing):

Role	Size	Weight / spacing
Hero display	<code>clamp(2.7rem, 7.4vw, 6rem)</code>	800, line-height .98, tracking -.025em
Page-hero H1	<code>clamp(2.4rem, 6vw, 4.4rem)</code>	800, lh 1.0, -.025em
H2 (section)	<code>clamp(1.9rem, 4.2vw, 3rem)</code>	700, lh 1.04, -.02em
H3 (card)	<code>1.2–1.5rem</code>	700, -.01em
Lede	<code>clamp(1.05rem, 1.7vw, 1.3rem)</code>	400, ink-soft
Body	<code>1.0625rem</code> (base 17px)	400, lh 1.6
Eyebrow / label	<code>0.72rem</code> mono	500, tracking .18em, UPPERCASE, brand color
Stat number	<code>clamp(2.2rem, 4vw, 3.2rem)</code>	display 800, -.03em

3.5 Spacing, radius, shadow

- **Radius:** cards `16px`, callout/CTA/join `18–22px`, pills/buttons `999px`, mono number chips `8px`.
- **Section rhythm:** large bands `padding-block: 80px`; standard `64px`; tight `44px`. Hero top `~92px`.
- **Borders over shadows.** Cards = `1px solid line` + `surface` fill; lift on hover with `translateY(-3px)` and a slightly darker border, *not* heavy drop shadows. Keep it blueprint-crisp. At most one soft shadow on the sticky header.
- Container max-width `1140px`, gutter `24px`.

3.6 Motion (tasteful, choreographed, reduced-motion-safe)

- **Always-on signature:** the conduit current (animated dashed gradient sliding ~30px loop) and the drop-feed marquee (continuous `translateX`, **pause on hover**). These carry the "flow" idea.
- **Page-load (hero only):** a short staggered reveal — eyebrow → headline → sub → CTAs → conduit, each rising 8–12px + fading, ~80ms apart, total under ~0.7s. Once.

- **Scroll reveal:** sections fade + rise on enter (IntersectionObserver, `ScrollReveal.tsx`), staggered for grids. Subtle — 12–16px, ~500ms.
- **Hover micro-interactions:** buttons lift 1px + color shift; cards lift 3px; arrow glyphs nudge `translateX(3px)`.
- `prefers-reduced-motion: reduce`: freeze the current, stop the marquee (make it a static, horizontally-scrollable row so content stays reachable), disable reveals and hovers, set transitions to ~0. This is a hard requirement.

3.7 Tailwind theme (encode the tokens)

```
ts

// tailwind.config.ts → theme.extend
colors: {
  bg: '#EEF1F8', surface: '#FFFFFF',
  ink: { DEFAULT: '#0A1730', 2: '#0E2147', soft: '#46506A' },
  line: '#D2DAEC',
  brand: { DEFAULT: '#2C57F6', deep: '#1B3CC2', soft: '#DEE6FE' },
  signal: '#FF5A36',
  ondark: { DEFAULT: '#EEF1F8', soft: '#B7C2DD', blue: '#8FA6FF' },
},
fontFamily: {
  display: ['"Bricolage Grotesque"', 'sans-serif'],
  sans: ['Inter', 'sans-serif'],
  mono: ['"JetBrains Mono"', 'monospace'],
},
borderRadius: { card: '16px', panel: '20px', pill: '999px' },
maxWidth: { site: '1140px' },
keyframes: {
  flow: { to: { transform: 'translateX(30px)' } },
  marquee: { to: { transform: 'translateX(-50%)' } },
  riseIn: { from: { opacity: '0', transform: 'translateY(12px)' }, to: { opacity: '1' } },
},
animation: {
  flow: 'flow 1.1s linear infinite',
  marquee: 'marquee 34s linear infinite',
  riseIn: 'riseIn .6s cubic-bezier(.2,.7,.2,1) both',
},
```

Add a faint sitewide blueprint grid as a fixed background layer: two 1px `brand`-at-5%-opacity linear-gradients on a 44px grid, masked to fade out toward the bottom.

4. Figma workflow (Phase 1 — do this before writing component code)

Use the connected Figma MCP to make the design real *in Figma first*, then implement to match. Goal: Figma is the source of truth; code mirrors it 1:1.

1. **Create a new Figma file:** "The Pipeline — Design System & Site."
 2. **Mirror tokens as Figma variables/styles:** every color in §3.3, the three font families + the §3.4 type scale as text styles, the §3.5 radii/spacing as variables. Include a light/dark distinction for surfaces (light page vs. ink bands).
 3. **Build the component library** (variants where noted) matching §3 and §6: `Button` (primary/ghost/ghostDark), `EyeBrow`, `SectionHead`, `ConduitRail`, `DropItem` + `DropFeed`, `Stat` + `StatGrid`, `StageCard`, `FeatureCard` (icon slot), `OutcomeCard` (default + CTA variant), `StepRow`, `Checklist`, `Callout`, `CtaBand`, `JoinCard`, `FaqItem`, `Header`, `Footer`. Bind components to the variables (no hardcoded hex).
 4. **Design the 5 screens** as frames at desktop (1440) and mobile (390) using those components, following the page specs in §6: Home, How It Works, Outcomes, About, Join. Make the hero + drop feed the visual anchor.
 5. **Set up Code Connect** mapping each Figma component to its Astro/React counterpart in `src/components/ui/...`, so the design system stays linked to code.
 6. If any MCP step is flaky or partial, **don't block** — this spec fully specifies the design, so proceed to code and keep Figma as the visual reference.
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5. Reusable components — quick specs

- **Header:** sticky, `bg` at 82% + blur, 1px bottom `line`. Brand (logo mark + wordmark) left; nav right: How it works · Outcomes · About · **Join** (filled `brand` pill). `aria-current="page"` styles the active link bold/ink. Mobile (<620px): nav wraps full-width under the brand, mono labels shrink. Keyboard-navigable, visible focus.
- **Logo mark:** rounded-square ink tile with a `brand` horizontal stem and a `signal` chevron arrow — literally "flow → arrival." Provide as inline SVG + `favicon.svg`.
- **Button:** pill, 14/24 padding. `primary` = `brand` fill / white, hover `brand-deep` + 1px lift. `ghost` = transparent / `line` border / ink. `ghostDark` = transparent / `dark-line` / white (for use on ink bands). Optional trailing `→` that nudges on hover.
- **Conduit:** 6px rounded `line` rail; inner animated dashed `brand` current; a `signal` dot "tip" at the right end with a soft glow. Decorative `→` `aria-hidden`.
- **DropFeed (island):** masked overflow strip framed by `dark-line` rails (the "pipe"), on an ink band. Mono items: `signal` dot + bold white name + mono uppercase role/outcome, separated by faint slashes. Duplicate the list once in JS for a seamless

loop; pause on hover; static + scrollable under reduced motion. Editable from `site.ts` in one place.

- **StatGrid:** 4 cells in a bordered, radius-`card`, `surface` strip; big display numbers with `brand` accent glyphs (\$, %, +); mono uppercase caption. Responsive 4→2→1.
 - **StageCard / FeatureCard / OutcomeCard:** `surface` + 1px `line`, radius `card`, hover lift. Stage has a mono `01 - Get in` step label + a tiny connector "pipe" between cards. Feature has a 30px stroke-icon in `brand`. Outcome has a `signal` dot top-right, big display org name, mono role; a special `is-cta` variant uses ink fill + a link.
 - **CtaBand / JoinCard:** ink (band) or `surface` (join) panel, radius `panel`, with a 5px top gradient bar `brand → signal`. Eyebrow + display H2 + lede + button row.
 - **Footer:** ink band. Row 1: brand + mono nav links. Row 2 (above a `dark-line`): "Built and run by fellows · UC Irvine" / "© 2026 The Pipeline".
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6. Pages

Every page = Header + content + Footer, with a Join-oriented CTA near the bottom.

Home (`index.astro`)

1. **Hero** — eyebrow `UC Irvine · Fellow-run · Est. 2026`; H1 "We don't fix the pipeline. We are the pipeline." (underline "are" in `signal`); lede on what they do (gatekept drops, resume reviews, mock interviews); CTAs `Join the Pipeline` + `See how it works`; the **Conduit** below with `Talent in` / `Offers out ↓` labels.
2. **Drop feed** — ink band, "Where our fellows have landed", the marquee, then a `See all outcomes →` link.
3. **Stats** — 50+ Fellows · 65% Landed an internship · \$0 To join · 100% Fellow-led.
4. **How-it-works teaser** — 3 StageCards + `See what every fellow gets →`.
5. **Mission teaser** — ink band, "The talent was *never* the problem." + `Read the whole story →`.
6. **CTA band** — "Get in the pipeline." + `How to join` + `Join the Discord`.

How It Works (`how.astro`)

Page-hero ("Three stages, one direction: forward.") + conduit → 3 expanded StageCards → "What every fellow gets" 6× FeatureCard grid (Gatekept job drops, Resume reviews, Mock interviews, Weekly office hours, Career strategy, People who pull you up) → "The loop" prose ("Every fellow who lands makes the next one more likely to.") → CTA band.

Page-hero ("Where our fellows **land.**", lede with the 65% line) → StatGrid → **placements grid** of OutcomeCards (one per landing) ending with the `is-cta` "...and the next one is yours." card → small mono note "Real outcomes from real fellows. More land every recruiting cycle." → CTA band.

About (`about.astro`)

Page-hero ("The talent was *never* the problem.") → 3-paragraph story (access was the missing piece; started as a Discord; grew to 50+ fellows; "we decided to be the pipeline") → **"What makes us different"** Checklist (Access handed over / Run by fellows not staff / Outcomes not vibes / Free and staying that way) → **"Going official"** Callout (becomes an official UCI student org this fall) → **FAQ** (4 items) → CTA band.

Join (`join.astro`)

Page-hero ("Get in the pipeline.") → **JoinCard** with a 3-StepRow flow (1 Join the Discord · 2 Fill the interest form · 3 Show up to office hours) + the two primary buttons + a partner/recruiter contact line → **"Once you're in"** Checklist of what changes.

404 (`404.astro`)

On-brand: eyebrow `Error 404`, H1 **"This one got gatekept."**, line "That page isn't here — but the opportunities are.", button back to Home. Same header/footer.

7. Content & data (`src/data/site.ts`)

Use this real content. Two TODOs the build must surface to the user:

```
ts
```

```

export const links = {
  discord: "https://discord.gg/REPLACE-WITH-INVITE", // TODO: real invite
  form:    "https://forms.gle/REPLACE-WITH-FORM",   // TODO: real interest
  contact: "mailto:REPLACE@uci.edu",                // TODO: real contact
};

// TODO: VERIFY each of these with the founder before publishing – do not inven
export const placements = [
  { org: "Capital One",      role: "SWE Intern · Final Round" },
  { org: "MLT",              role: "Career Prep" },
  { org: "Break Through Tech", role: "@ Cornell" },
  { org: "American Express",  role: "Internship" },
  { org: "Amazon",           role: "Full-Time Offer" },
];

export const stats = [
  { num: "50+", cap: "Fellows" },
  { num: "65%", cap: "Landed an internship" },
  { num: "$0", cap: "To join" },
  { num: "100%", cap: "Fellow-led" },
];

export const faq = [
  { q: "Who is this for?", a: "Undergrads underrepresented in tech –" },
  { q: "What does it cost?", a: "Nothing. The Pipeline is free, and th" },
  { q: "Do I have to go to UC Irvine?", a: "The Pipeline started at UC Irvine a" },
  { q: "How much time does it take?", a: "As much or as little as you need – us" },
];

```

Mission/voice strings to reuse verbatim: the hero thesis, *"The talent was never the problem."*, and *"They called us the pipeline problem. We decided to be the pipeline."* Keep all copy plain, confident, specific. Do not add buzzwords or pity framing.

8. Quality bar (non-negotiable)

- **Responsive:** flawless from 360px → ultrawide. Grids collapse 4→2→1 / 3→2→1. No horizontal overflow.
- **Accessibility:** semantic landmarks (`header/nav/main/section/footer`), a visible **skip-to-content** link, `aria-current` on active nav, keyboard operable, `:focus-visible` rings (blue on light, `ondark.blue` on dark), decorative motifs `aria-hidden`. Check

contrast: `brand` and `signal` must pass AA on their backgrounds for any text use (use ink/white for body text, not the accents).

- **Performance:** Lighthouse ≥ 95 across the board. Self-host fonts via `@fontsource/bricolage-grotesque`, `@fontsource-variable/inter`, `@fontsource/jetbrains-mono` (only the weights used); `font-display: swap`. Ship JS only for `DropFeed` + `ScrollReveal` islands. Lazy-load anything below the fold. Inline the critical SVGs.
 - **SEO:** per-page `<title>` + meta description + canonical + Open Graph/Twitter tags via `Layout.astro` props. Generate `sitemap-index.xml` (`@astrojs/sitemap`; set `site:` in `astro.config.mjs`), add `robots.txt`, `favicon.svg`, and a 1200×630 `og.png` social card (ink bg, wordmark, the thesis line, the conduit motif).
 - **Reduced motion** handled per §3.6.
-

9. Build sequence (phases — execute in order)

1. **Figma first** — §4: create the file, mirror tokens as variables, build the component library, design all 5 screens (desktop + mobile), wire Code Connect. (If MCP partial, note it and continue.)
2. **Scaffold** — §2 setup, `astro.config.mjs` (`site:`), `tailwind.config.ts` with the §3.7 theme, `global.css` (Tailwind layers + base type + blueprint-grid bg + reduced-motion block), self-hosted fonts.
3. **Primitives** — `Layout`, `Header`, `Footer`, `Button`, `Eyebrow`, `SectionHead`, `Conduit`. Get the header/footer/nav + active state perfect across breakpoints before moving on.
4. **Data** — `src/data/site.ts` from §7 (with the TODO markers intact).
5. **Feature components** — `DropFeed` (island, seamless loop, hover-pause, reduced-motion fallback), `StatGrid`, `StageCard`, `FeatureCard`, `OutcomeCard` (+CTA), `StepRow`, `Checklist`, `Callout`, `CtaBand`, `JoinCard`, `Faq`.
6. **Pages** — build Home → How → Outcomes → About → Join → 404 (§6), composing components and pulling copy from `site.ts`.
7. **Motion** — `ScrollReveal` island + hero load stagger + always-on signature, all guarded by `prefers-reduced-motion`.
8. **QA** — responsive sweep (360/390/768/1024/1440), keyboard + focus pass, axe/Lighthouse, fix to ≥ 95 . Verify no leftover hardcoded colors (all via tokens).
9. **Ship** — §10.

After Phase 9, **surface the open TODOs to me**: confirm the placements list, and supply the real Discord invite, interest-form URL, and contact — then I (Claude Code) wire them in.

10. Deploy

Static output → host anywhere. Easiest: **Netlify** (`npx netlify deploy --prod`), or connect the GitHub repo — Astro is auto-detected, build (`npm run build`), publish (`dist/`) or **Vercel** / **Cloudflare Pages**. Set the production domain in (`astro.config.mjs`) (`site:`) so canonicals + sitemap are correct. Confirm the live build hits Lighthouse ≥95 and that every internal link + the Join buttons resolve.

Definition of done

- ☐ Figma file with tokens-as-variables, full component library, and 5 screens (desktop + mobile); Code Connect wired.
- ☐ Astro + Tailwind + TS project; all tokens in theme; zero hardcoded hex in components.
- ☐ 6 pages built from shared components, copy sourced from (`site.ts`).
- ☐ Signature conduit + drop feed working; motion choreographed; reduced-motion fully respected.
- ☐ Responsive 360px→ultrawide, no overflow; AA contrast; keyboard + focus-visible; skip link.
- ☐ SEO complete (titles, meta, OG, sitemap, robots, favicon, og.png); Lighthouse ≥95.
- ☐ TODOs surfaced: placements verified, Discord/form/contact filled.
- ☐ Deployed to a live URL.